Red Diaper Baby

By Josh Kornbluth

FATHER: *(Singing)** ***Arise, you prisoners of starvation! / Arise, you wretched of the earth!***

For justice thunders condemnation. / A better world's in birth.

JOSH: My father, Paul Kornbluth, was a Communist. He believed there was going to be a violent Communist revolution in this country -- and that I was going to lead it. Just so you can get a sense of the pressure.

INTRODUCTION

It's a morning in the mid-1960s, and 6-year-old Josh Kornbluth is woken by his father, Paul, in the usual manner -- with Paul bursting naked into Josh's room and singing "The Internationale." So begins this raucous tale of a young American communist's coming-of-age The true story of a boy whose dream is to lead a revolution. Quite a challenge, especially for such a shy, chubby kid.

Red Diaper Baby by Josh Kornbluth

JOSH: Anything my father told me I'd believe, because my father was such a physically magnificent man: he was big, and he had this great big potbelly -- not a wiggly-jiggly, Social Democratic potbelly; a firm, Communist potbelly. You bopped it, it would bop you back. It was ***strong***.

I would have loved to have slept in late on the weekends, but I couldn't because my father wouldn't let me. He'd come bursting into my room and running up to my bed, looming over me he'd sing: ***Arise, ye prisoner of starvation! Arise, ye wretched of the earth!*** I didn't know that was the international Communist anthem. I thought it was my own personal wake-up song. I knew from an early age that one day I must grow up and lead the Revolution!

My father had his own language -- not only his own English, but his own Yiddish. I used to think it was real Yiddish, but my mom would say

MOTHER: What your father speaks is not Yiddish. I went to Yiddish school and what your father speaks is ***not*** Yiddish.

JOSH: In my father's Yiddish, there was a term ***ouska*** **--** a prefix, meaning "a lot of," "very"

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

FATHER: I am ***ouska****-cold,* my son!"

JOSH: *(to father)* Of course you're ***ouska***-cold, Dad; the window is ***ouska***-open."

Dad and I would sit around the kitchen table having hard-boiled eggs (my father, not a soft-boiled kind of guy). And Dad would regale me with his stories of organizing with the Henry Wallace campaign. (That's ****Henry*** Wallace. ***Henry****.* Okay?) And he'd drill me in the catechisms of our faith of Communism. Like how society has been driven from one stage to the next, driven inexorably by the forces of dialectical materialism, until ...

According to Marx and Engels -- and my dad -- the first human society was Primitive Communalism: everyone's just kind of dancing around, like at a Grateful Dead concert.

The next stage after Primitive Communalism was Slavery -- which must have been a bummer of a transition.

Then from Slavery to Feudalism, and from Feudalism ... Well, we've learned from history that it's very important after Feudalism to stop in Capitalism before moving on to Socialism. Very important to stop in Capitalism. Because that's where you get your appliances.

So you stop in Capitalism, you get your stuff, and ***then*** you move on to Socialism, and finally to Communism -- and you're back at the concert.

All along the walls of our kitchen, bathroom, living-room and dining-room area were posters of our heroes, our gods: W. E. B. Du Bois, Malcolm X, Dr. King, Ho Chi Minh, Bertolt Brecht, Emma Goldman . . . And at the end of all these posters: my height chart.

And we'd go outside for our walks. When we went outside, my father -- in his one true concession to society -- would put on clothing. This was back in '65, when I was about six years old; and being Communists, we had songs associated with ***every*** activity. Me and Dad didn't just have ***generic*** walking songs; we had ***specific*** going-up-the-hill songs, ***specific*** going-down-the-hill songs.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

We learned our biggest going-up-the-hill song off an album by Paul Robeson, a great Jewish folksinger. It was a record my dad had borrowed from the public library, and then -- as a revolutionary act refused to return. (And my mom was a librarian!)

Going downhill, [we] would sing: *********As I go down in the valley [to the river] to pray / Studying about that good old way / And who shall wear the robe and crown / Good Lord, show me the way!***

My father couldn't hear me. He didn't connect it with the fact that he was singing so ***ouska***-loud he was drowning me out. So periodically he'd turn to me on the sidewalk and go

FATHER: Sing louder, my son-I can't hear you! *(singing loudly)* ***Come on, fathers, let's go down! / Down in the valley to pra-a-a-ay ... to pray-yee!*** *(declaring emphatically)* And a child shall lead them!

JOSH: A nice, cheerful walking song-though confusing lyrically, to an urban child. *(beat)* We had to live ***ouska***-cheaply. Because my father . . . Well, he was a schoolteacher -- a very good schoolteacher with great passion, but at the same time he would be developing this ***anger*** towards his bosses: the principal, the assistant principals, the school board. And this anger at his bosses would build and build, until finally Dad couldn't take it anymore. This would take about two weeks. And at the end of those two weeks, Dad would go storming into the principal's office and yell

FATHER: F*** you!

JOSH: Often the guy would never have seen my dad before. And he'd say, "You're fired! ... If you work for me, you're fired!" And then Dad would get another job, and he'd be teaching his new students with great passion but developing this anger towards his new bosses. And at the end of two weeks he would storm into his new principal's office and go

FATHER: F*** you!

JOSH: And the new principal would go; "You're fired!" This went on for years and years; my father never saw the pattern. He never saw the cause-and-effect between "F*** you!" and "You're fired!" So we had to live ***ouska***-cheaply. Which was fine with me: I loved ***ouska***-cheap adventures, like the Museum of Natural History -- where at the time the admission was

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

whatever you would care to donate. They've since changed that policy; I think because of my dad.

FATHER: Pay them a penny and not a penny more!

JOSH: We'd go running to the dinosaur exhibit, where Dad would give me a tour. I don't think he was an expert in the field, but . . .

FATHER: The Tyrannosaurus rex, my son-one of the largest . . . reptilian(s) ever to walk the earth!

JOSH: And other little kids would break away from their field trips and join us. [It] was a lot more interesting the way my dad described it. (beat) And then, after a weekend of this kind of ***ouska***-fun, my dad -- as the courts had mandated -- had to return me to . . . my mom -- Bernice "Bunny" Selden: also Jewish, also a New Yorker, also a college grad, also a Communist -- but so different from my father in temperament. If my father was an out-there, ***ouska***-Communist, my mom was ... ***inska***.

And she had her own ***inska***-wake-up song for me, too. And like I thought Dad had written the "Internationale" for me, I thought my mom had written ***her*** wake-up song for me; I only found out years later that Irving Berlin wrote it.

She'd go into the bathroom in her nightgown and come back out with her hair in a bun. And she'd stand in my open doorway -- which was easy for her to do, because for some reason she would not let me have a door. She'd tiptoe to my bed and lean down and sing:

MOTHER: *(singing)* ********Oh, how I hate to get up in the morning / Oh, how I'd love to stay in bed***
For the hardest blow of all / Is to hear that bugler call:
"You gotta get up, you gotta get up; You gotta get up in the morning.
You gotta get up, you gotta get up, You gotta get up in the morning."

JOSH: A pretty nice wake-up song. Unless you know the second verse, which gets to a surreal level of violence . . .

MOTHER: *(singing)* ***Someday I'm gonna murder the bugler / Someday you're gonna find him dead / I'll amputate his reveille / And stamp upon it heavily/ And spend the rest of my life in bed!***

JOSH: I thought she could snap at any moment. So I'd get out of bed; I didn't want my reveille

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

amputated! *(beat)* But I still didn't have that get-up-and-go that the "Internationale" gives a kid. She'd guid lead me into the living room and sit me down on the couch. She had this little motherly trick she'd play to get me going in the morning: she'd serve me a tall cup of double-espresso with whipped cream and a maraschino cherry on top.

And I'd sit there sipping my double-espresso on the couch, beneath the half-dozen ceramic disks that she bought in Mexico, where she went to divorce my dad -- which, by the way, was when I was six months old.

They were married for nine years, then I was born. Then, when I was six months old, they divorced. From time to time I'd wonder why. *(beat)* A few months ago, I was reading this article about a guy named Saul Newton, a crazed psychoanalyst who ran this cult called the Sullivanians. They had a co-op on the Upper West Side. *(thoughtfully)* Saul Newton . . . Saul Newton -- and suddenly it hit me: Wait a second! My **dad's** therapist was named Saul! So I called up my mom and said, "Mom, I'm reading about this Saul Newton guy," and she said, "Yeah, that was your father's therapist." Evidently Dad was an early patient of Saul's -- sort of a test case.

After I was born, Saul convinced my dad that now that he had a family, and families were evil, his family must be broken up. So, Dad left me and my mom and got an apartment on the Lower East Side. According to my mom, after a couple of weeks Dad started to miss us. He came running to try to reconcile with us. But Mom escaped with me down to Mexico, where she got the divorce, bought big, floppy hats, danced around with strangers, and got the half-dozen or so ceramic disks -- each one depicts a woman escaping from slavery.

So I'd sit there under the disks on the couch, sipping my double espresso, as my mom turned on the old radio. The morning disc jockey was Julius Lester -- he of the ***ouska***-deep voice. Supposedly, Julius's program was a classical music show. But Julius would play about five minutes of an oboe concerto, and then speak for hours about his various ex-wives and their peccadilloes.

I'd listen to Julius and sip my double-espresso and then go running off to school-jazzed!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I was so excited my first day of kindergarten. After spending the first five years of my life exclusively in the company of my parents and their friends; for the first time, I was going to get to mingle with the masses. Boy, was I disappointed! That first day, I walked into my kindergarten classroom and saw all these little kids running around screaming, pulling hair, bopping each other, crying. I thought, How will I ever organize ***these*** people? *(then he gets an idea)* Remember . . . my father was a Communist. He believed I was going to lead a violent Communist revolution – so . . . *(singing as a 5-year-old)* * ***Arise, you prisoners of starvation! / Arise, you wretched of the earth! / For justice thunders condemnation. / A better world's in birth.***

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Josh Kornbluth
ISBN: 978-1562790875
Publisher: Mercury House Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Oct 1996

AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier

**The Internationale is a revolutionary socialist anthem, with lyrics by Eugène Pottier, and music by Pierre Degeyter. The song became a powerful symbol of international socialist solidarity and revolutionary struggle. It has been translated into many languages and remains relevant today for various socialist and leftist groups.*

Music and lyrics in English: ***https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UrMwNuS7aUQ***

*** In the presidential campaign of 1948, Henry Wallace set out to challenge the conventional wisdom of his time, blaming the United States, instead of the Soviet Union, for the Cold War, denouncing the popular Marshall Plan, and calling for an end to segregation. In addition, he argued that domestic fascism--rather than international communism--posed the primary threat to the nation. He even welcomed Communists into his campaign, admiring their commitment to peace.*

**** Down to the River to Pray music*
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zSif77IVQdY

******Oh How I Hate To Get Up In the Morning (1918)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CnH-bkp277Q

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY